



Unity in the Word

The Zeme's journey to a Bible translation

Suppose you're a church leader in a large people group. You've noticed a problem: though the church has existed among your people for over a hundred years, the only translation of the Bible in their language is hard to understand and isn't widely used among the local churches.

This is a worrying situation. Your people need a better translation if discipleship and church growth is to continue, but it will be hard to get outside help



CBBT Case Study: Zeme | 1



LANGUAGE OVERVIEW

Country:	India
People group:	Zeme
Language:	Northern Zeme
Native speakers:	125,000
Status:	Minimally Reached**

*name changed for security

**status from Joshua Project

TRANSLATION OVERVIEW

People involved: **37**
Time active: **Jan 2021 - Oct 2022**
Result: **Full Bible**
Outside funding: **\$0**

because you already have a translation—despite the fact that it doesn't meet your needs. What do you do?

This is the predicament in which the Zeme of northeastern India found themselves. The Zeme are a tribe in Nagaland, a lush, wooded state bordering Myanmar. Missionaries introduced Christianity to the tribe in the late 19th century, and most of the tribe joined the growing church throughout the 20th century. Today, the tribe is predominantly Christian and numbers about 125,000.

Thanks to the long history of the Zeme church, the people were theologically mature and established in the faith. However, they found the existing translation of the Bible into their language, Northern Zeme, hard to understand because it didn't accurately represent the way Northern Zeme was spoken. Thus, Zeme church leaders were interested when a local organization—Bridge Connectivity Solutions—told them about Church-Based Bible Translation. BCS, which specializes in technology and localization services throughout India, explained how CBBT could meet their translation needs by enabling them to effectively complete a translation



that would be used by the community. Motivated, the church leaders came up with a detailed plan of action. The goal? To complete the translation by the 125th anniversary of the Benreu Baptist Union, marking 125 years of the church in the Zeme people group. This gave them just twenty-one months to translate the entire Bible.

Translation work begins

Translation work commenced in January 2021. The first step was to form a team. Church leaders appointed fourteen full-time staff, some with advanced theological training.

When including part-time staff and volunteers, the total number of people involved in the translation



project was thirty-seven. Some of these came from BCS, and some came from the local churches. The project was facilitated by the Benreu Baptist Union.

The team got to work immediately. The first problem they encountered was a lack of proper technological training. The team used software like translationCore, Autographa, and Paratext, but many of the team members did not know how to use this software or how to use computers in general. BCS stepped in to provide laptops and seven days of software training.

The team faced another challenge during the “community check” phase of the translation. During

“**The Bible translation project has brought [us] together.**

Zeme leader

community check, the translation team presents the translation to speakers of the target language to check if it is understandable and appealing (“appealing,” among other things, means that the translation is natural, economical, and beautiful). When the Zeme translation team started community check, they realized that the people to whom they



showed the translation disagreed on whether what they had read constituted a good translation.

BCS taught the community check participants what should be present in a good translation. Many of the participants were hearing this for the first time. The training sessions enabled them to resolve their disagreements about the appeal of the text, and the work proceeded as scheduled.

Throughout the project, the team faced the tension between the efficiency required by the looming deadline and the care demanded by the fact that they were translating the word of God. If they rushed the work, they might end up with an untrustworthy translation. But if they spent too long on it, they risked not finishing on time. To resolve this, they restructured the translation team so that more people could work on quality assurance rather than drafting. This allowed the translation work to proceed effectively without fear of poor quality.



The project complete

The Zeme were committed to their ambitious timeline. They finished the translation in October 2022 and presented it at the Benreu Baptist Union's 125th-anniversary celebration that December.



**The project has
prepared effective
church leaders for the
future.**

Zeme leader

Thanks to Church-Based Bible Translation, the Northern Zeme language community has a complete, trustworthy, and usable translation of the

Scriptures for use in discipleship and church planting. Importantly, the translation team has acquired the skill and expertise necessary to revise the translation in future years, ensuring its usefulness to the Zeme for years to come.

